Aviation, maritime transport take center stage in ETS talks

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By TOMMASO LECCA with JORDYN DAHL and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — The Commission

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SNEAK PEEK

— The Commission's ETS proposals for aviation and maritime transport are emerging as major sticking points, with the first compromise drafts on the entire revision expected next week.

— The International Road Transport Union is warning of "growing discontent" among haulers in the EU, and urging the Commission to tackle soaring diesel prices.

— ITRE and TRAN rubber-stamped the compromised deal on emission targets for automakers, but industry is not impressed.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

Mark your calendars: Our weekly mobility calendar landed in your inbox on Thursday. You can also go online to export and plan your week or suggest your own event.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

DRIVING THE DAY

ETS NEGOTIATIONS TO GET SERIOUS: More than three months after the European Commission proposed a revision of the Emissions Trading System — which includes measures with strong implications for the aviation and maritime sectors — the Council and Parliament are close to producing their respective first compromise drafts, initial attempts to reconcile competing positions on the legislation.

See you next week? Three people following the negotiations in the two institutions told Tommaso they expect the first compromise drafts from the Irish Council presidency and Parliament's rapporteur Peter Liese to circulate next week.

Tight schedule: These drafts will form the basis of the positions that EU countries and MEPs aim to adopt by the end of the year. The Irish Council presidency is targeting the Dec. 11 meeting of environment ministers to adopt a general approach, while Parliament is expected to pass its position during the December plenary session.

The big question is how far the two institutions will depart from the Commission's text, with the proposed extensions of the ETS in aviation and maritime transport emerging as some of the most contentious issues.

Make ETS European again: The proposed ETS extension to flights departing the EU for destinations within 5,000 kilometers of Frankfurt is expected to spark opposition in the Council, where France has already emerged as a leading opponent of the measure at the latest meeting of environment ministers.

Paris' allies: Back in June, before the Commission presented its proposal, Paris opposed any extension of the ETS to emissions outside the EU during a Transport Council meeting , supporting instead the U.N.'s Carbon Offsetting and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation for non-EU aircraft emissions. Some of the seven countries that supported France on that occasion — such as Italy and Latvia — are expected to maintain their reservations about the ETS extension. Others, such as Finland, are also skeptical of the proposal.

Meanwhile in Strasbourg: Parliament's shadow rapporteurs met Liese on Thursday, a MEP aide told Tommaso. During the meeting, the Socialists & Democrats expressed support for an even broader geographical scope for the aviation ETS. Parliament remains divided, with some 3,500 amendments submitted to the entire text.

From airports to ports: The shipping industry supports some aspects of the Commission proposal, including the proposed Sustainable Maritime Alternative Propulsion mechanism, which would channel part of ETS revenues toward decarbonizing shipping. But some EU countries and MEPs are expected to oppose other measures, such as extending carbon pricing to vessels between 400 and 5,000 gross tonnage and applying the full cost of ETS compliance on ships that stop in some non-EU ports before reaching a European hub.

TRUCKS

TRUCKER UNREST GOES EU-WIDE: The International Road Transport Union is warning Brussels of "growing discontent among road transport operators" across the bloc and urging Commission President Ursula von der Leyen to take EU-level action to ease the pressure of soaring diesel prices, as Italy grapples with trucker blockades disrupting food and fuel supplies.

All-around problem: In a letter sent on Thursday and seen by POLITICO, IRU said neither it nor its national federations support the recent disruptions but warned that there's growing discontent among operators that is being driven above all by surging diesel prices linked to the Middle East crisis.

The numbers behind the anger: IRU says trucks, buses and coaches consume around 6.8 billion liters of diesel every month across the EU, while fuel accounts for about 30% of road freight operating costs. Most operators are small and medium enterprises or microbusinesses working on margins of just 1% to 3%, and many also face payment delays of 90 to 180 days, leaving them with little room to absorb sudden cost increases.

What they want: IRU is asking Brussels for two concrete measures. First, it wants the Middle East Crisis Temporary State Aid Framework extended by one year, until the end of 2027, while preserving the option for national governments to compensate operators for up to 70% of additional fuel costs. It is also urging the Commission to encourage faster use of the framework, including advance payments where appropriate.

And a structural fix: The second ask is a dedicated EU regulation on late payments in road transport, with a strict 30-day maximum payment period and stronger enforcement. IRU says chronic delays force smaller operators to effectively finance much larger customers, weakening their balance sheets and leaving less money available for fleet renewal, green investment and digitalization.

Italy as warning sign: The letter lands as southern Italy's trucker protests continue to choke supply chains despite Rome promising fresh support. Supermarket shortages, dry petrol stations and transport disruption have shown how quickly stress in road freight can spill into the wider economy — the same kind of knock-on effect IRU is warning Brussels about.

LOGISTICS SECTOR SEEKS CLARITY ON EU PACKAGING RULES: Postal, express, freight forwarding and cold-storage groups are urging the Commission to simplify the EU's Packaging and Packaging Waste Regulation , warning that unclear rules on transport packaging, reusable assets and producer responsibility risk adding costs and disrupting supply chains.

What's bothering them: The groups sent a letter to the Commission saying reuse targets could force operators to manage different obligations depending on who receives the goods, while tracking pallets and other reusable packaging across large networks could require significant new systems and investment.

What they want: Clear EU-wide guidance on who counts as a producer or manufacturer, how shipping labels and imported packaging should be treated, how to avoid double EPR charging, and how obligations apply to freight forwarders and logistics providers handling goods entering the EU.

CARS

ITRE AND TRAN APPROVE CO2 COMPROMISE: The two opinion committees on Thursday rubber-stamped a compromise deal on the emission targets for automakers. ENVI, the leading committee, is up next on Nov. 4. But like any good compromise, it's left much to be desired for the industry.

Catch up: The deal — negotiated between the EPP, S&D and Renew groups — would set a 2035 emission reduction target of 87.5% of 2021 levels, with 5% of the emissions not requiring any offsets and 7.5% of the emissions able to be offset through green steel investments.

We tried: "Today's vote confirms the strength of the agreement reached among the majority groups, following a long and arduous negotiation," said ITRE shadow rapporteur Giorgio Gori of the S&D. "It maintains the decarbonization objective while introducing necessary flexibility."

We see potential: EU car lobby ACEA said it "sees the potential of several proposed flexibilities," but it fails to address all of the industry's concerns. The final outcome, they said, needs to be more pragmatic.

We're not happy: German auto lobby VDA had harsher words. Although the deal "contains clear improvements over the European Commission's original proposal, it does not go far enough to ensure the competitiveness of Europe as a manufacturing hub," VDA said in a statement . The group wants the emission target set to an unconditional 90% and for any green steel mechanism to include other carbon-neutral materials like aluminum.

Victory lap: The EPP, meanwhile, used the vote to tout it is making good on its campaign promise to overturn the combustion engine ban. "The deal is agreed and the EPP Group is keeping its word. Together with our partners, we have agreed to reverse the combustion engine ban. This gives the car

industry the flexibility it needs to transform and businesses greater certainty to plan and invest," TRAN rapporteur Jens Gieseke said in a press release .

IAA MEETING A 'TAME AFFAIR': Two parliamentary officials described the kickoff meeting between the leaders and shadow MEPs on the Industrial Accelerator Act as a tame affair, where camps laid out red lines and negotiables. "There is a lot of work ahead of us but also a strong willingness to work together and get it done," Anna Cavazzini of the Greens, co-leader on the file for the trade committee, told our colleague Francesca Micheletti.

Tough path for Made in Europe: If there's one clear takeaway, it's that a strict "Made in Europe" club, as envisaged by the co-rapporteurs Cavazzini, Pierre Jouvet (Socialists & Democrats) and Christophe Grudler (Renew), will be very hard to pull through — except for cars. The Franco-German agreement on CO2 standards and the IAA wasn't central to the discussion, one of the officials said, but it seems to suggest that "opt in" will be the favored approach for the automotive sector.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Europe's satellite merger tests push for space independence
The deal among Airbus, Leonardo and Thales seeks to strengthen the European space industry, but could leave the EU with fewer suppliers for its own secure communications network.
By Francesca Micheletti, Jacopo Barigazzi · Oct 23, 2026, 06:00 am Europe/Brussels CEST

The Democrats' looming trade battle
Trump's aggressive — and unpopular — use of tariffs in his second term has created an opening for more trade-friendly voices in the party, after a decade in the political wilderness.
By Daniel Desrochers · Oct 23, 2026, 01:15 am Europe/Brussels CEST

Trucker blockades in southern Italy ramp up pressure on Meloni
The prime minister has vowed to break blockades, but has also offered relief to farmers and fishermen over sky-high diesel costs.
By Hannah Roberts, Martina Sapio · Oct 22, 2026, 06:52 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

EU Parliament reaches deal on competitiveness fund
By Aude van den Hove · Oct 22, 2026, 12:52 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Weekly Calendar

Here's a selection of upcoming key events, find the complete Week Ahead online.

Eurocontrol 'Aviation Week MRO Europe' Event
Oct 27, 2026, 9:00 AM - Oct 29, 2026, 10:00 AM · Amsterdam, NL

IATA Cybersecurity Summit
Oct 28, 2026 - Oct 29, 2026 · Geneva, CH

IATA 'Implications of the Proposals in the UN Framework Convention on Tax Cooperation on International Aviation' webinar
Oct 28, 2026 · Online

Coreper I
Oct 28, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Coreper II
Oct 28, 2026 · Brussels, BE

CANSO Academy ‘Considerations for Ground and Space-Based ADS-B Implementation’ webinar
Oct 29, 2026 · Online

Transport, Telecommunications and Energy Council Event
Oct 29, 2026 · Luxembourg, LU

Pro Roundtable – Agriculture
Oct 29, 2026, 8:15 AM - 9:45 am

Council Ad Hoc Working Party On Military Mobility
Oct 30, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Eurocontrol: Audit Board Ad Hoc
Oct 30, 2026, 9:00 AM - 12:00 pm · Brussels, BE

Pro Intelligence Connections
2021/0211(COD) Revision of the EU Emissions Tradin…
Discussions within the Council or its preparatory…
2021/0207(COD) Revision of the EU Emissions Tradin…
Final act published in Official Journal
2022/0396(COD) Packaging and packaging waste
Final act published in Official Journal

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